## 2002

The pro-Musharraf PML (Quaid), led by Mian Muhammad Azhar, won 118 seats, with PPP, led by Ameen Faheem (with Benazir still in exile and sentenced in a corruption case) winning 81. Muttahida Majlis-i-Amal (MMA)—an alliance of right-wing, religious parties—won 60 seats, while PML-N won 19

★ PML-Q in alliance with MMA formed the government, with Mir Zafarullah Khan Jamali becoming PM. He resigned owing to differences with the military in 2004; Shaukat Aziz appointed PM

★ Rising terrorism, the Lal Masjid operation, the killing of Baloch leader Akbar Bugti forced Musharraf to impose emergency in 2007. He announced polls in 2008, which were overshadowed by the assassination of Benazir Bhutto in Dec. 2007



## 2008

Riding a sympathy wave, the PPP won 122 seats out of 272, with the PML-N winning 92 and the PML-Q 41. With MQM and Awami Nationalist Party (ANP), they formed a coalition, with **Yusuf Raza Gilani** being made PM

★ Impeachment proceedings were started against Gen. Musharraf, who left the country and went into exile

★ Gilani was disqualified by the Supreme Court in 2012 for "contempt of court", and was succeeded by Raja Pervez Ashraf

★ When fresh polls were called in 2013, it was the first time a civilian government had lasted five years without its tenure cut short by the military, or presidents controlled by it

## 2013

The PML-N, again led by Sharif and allied with PML-Q and ANP, won 126 seats out of 272, while PPP led by Zardari won 38 seats. It saw the emergence of Imran's PTI as a significant new force, winning 27 seats. Heading a coalition, Sharif took over as PM for the third time

★ Sharif was dismissed by the SC on charges of concealing assets in 2017 after his name featured in the Panama Papers

## 2018

The 2018 general election saw Imran Khan's PTI win 116 seats, with PML-N, now led by Shehbaz Sharif—his brother Nawaz still disqualified and in exile—winning 64 and the PPP coming third after winning 43. Imran formed the government with MQM and PML-Q, and was sworn in as PM

★ His gradual falling out with the army amid a deepening economic crisis in the pandemic years saw him being isolated, and he was voted out in a no-confidence motion in April 2022

★ The PML-N, PPP and other parties came together in the Pakistan Democratic Movement (PDM) alliance to oust Imran; Shehbaz became the PM as consensus candidate

*– Compiled by Saikat Niyogi*



expensive items he kept for himself from state-level gifts and his violation of the Official Secrets Act in the infamous 'cipher' case. What incensed many, however, was the third judgment, in which he and his wife Bushra were convicted of having contracted their marriage before Bushra had completed the traditional Islamic period of 'iddat' or waiting after her previous marriage. Even those opposed to Imran and his frequent demagoguery were outraged at the State getting involved in what was essentially an entirely private matter. PTI supporters obviously saw it as just another instance of Imran being treated grossly unjustly, and the turnout may have reflected this.

But does it mean Imran could soon be out and free again? Most astute observers doubt it. There are still plenty of obstacles for the PTI, even if it has the largest block of seats in the National Assembly. For one, they are technically all Independents outside the constraints of party discipline, and fears are being expressed that the other parties may try to cajole or bribe some of them to break away and join them. A trickle has already started heading to the PML-N. To prevent this from happening, it is possible that the PTI will ask its Independent members to join a smaller party that is recognised by the ECP for these assemblies. It is already in talks with the religio-political party Majlis-e-Wahdat-e-Muslimeen (MWM). Joining another party—which Independents are allowed to do within three days of being notified—would place them under the umbrella of laws that prevent floor crossing.

Another hurdle is the reserved seats allocated to women and minorities, which will eventually swell the number of seats in parliament. These reserved seats are allocated in proportion to the number of seats won by political parties—but not by Independents. The PTI's grievance is that the MWM has not given a big enough list of candidates for the reserved list, as the ECP stipulates. This, in addition to the PTI contesting results it deems were manipulated, could also land up as petitions in the courts. Would the PTI be able to get court orders in time to circumvent the formation of governments and their political repercussions? The possibility seems remote.

Does the PTI have the street power to unleash chaos through protests? Also unlikely, especially in light of the crackdown after its last such adventure on May 9, 2023. But the State and even the PML-N might want to reduce the polarisation in the country by giving the PTI some concessions.